

Songs beneath the sea

Filled with deep rumbles, creaking sounds, and squeaks, the humpback whale's song is one of the longest and eeriest in the animal world. A complete song can last for more than 15 minutes and contains separate themes and phrases that slowly change over a period of years. Only the males sing, and whales in the same social group sing the same song, with the same variations, even if they are thousands of miles apart. No one knows exactly why whales sing. The most likely explanation is that it helps males to attract potential mates.



Treetop chorus

Leaf-eating howler monkeys are among the world's loudest land animals. They live in tropical forests and use their roaring calls to signal to neighboring troops up to 3 miles (5 km) away. The chorus warns the neighbors to keep their distance and not to compete with the troop for food. In their throats, howlers have an extra-large hyoid bone.

Shaped like a bowl, it makes sound reverberate when they call.



Flight feathers reverberate when wings are flicked together

Bird musicians

In addition to singing, birds communicate in other ways. Woodpeckers signal by hammering on tree trunks, while many birds clatter their beaks, or clap their wingtips together when they fly. Some of the strangest sounds are made by club-winged manakins. Males have special wing feathers with large, hollow shafts. They flick these together over their backs, making a sound like a wheezy violin.

Insect sounds

Insects do not have lungs, so they cannot make sounds by breathing. Instead, many kinds chirp or sing by rubbing one body part against another—a technique called stridulation. Most grasshoppers, such as this one, rub their hind legs against their forewings. Their hind legs have a row of small pegs, which scrape against the wings to make sound. Crickets sing in a slightly different way, by rubbing one forewing against the other.



Inner surface of grasshopper's hind leg rubs against thickened forewing